

Effortless Calm



Eight Ways To Calm Yourself In Chaos



VALERIE MIRTO

“Overwhelm ceases when we pause in the storm
and reclaim calm.”

Picture this: a woman perched high on a unicycle, juggling multiple spinning plates while talking on the phone. If that image feels all too familiar, it's safe to say you're no stranger to stress.

You might tell yourself you're managing just fine in your crazy-busy lifestyle, but I encourage you to take a closer look. Do you often feel frazzled, chronically exhausted, or find yourself making compromises you'd rather avoid? Are there items on your "to-do later" list that keep getting postponed as you scramble to stay ahead of the chaos?

If any of this sounds like you, it might be time to invite some calm into your life.

No matter how different our lives may look, one thing is certain: change is inevitable. And more often than not, change is experienced as stress—even the positive kind. From keeping adrenaline pumping to overtaxing the nervous system, stress can drain your personal energy faster than you realize.

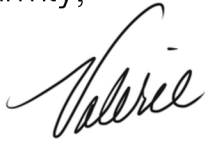
So, what's the solution to all the spinning? Make a better plan.

By planning for the unexpected and keeping simple, effective tools at your fingertips, you can better manage the waves of stress that life throws your way.

Here's the key: calming the chaos doesn't have to be hard. If you're ready to make changes, you don't have to overhaul everything at once. Baby steps are not only manageable but often more effective. Small, intentional actions build momentum and make it easier to create lasting habits.

The following steps are designed to help you begin welcoming more calm into your life. May they inspire you to pause, reconnect, and find the tranquility that's always within reach — even on your most chaotic days.

Warmly,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Valerie". The signature is fluid and cursive, with a long, sweeping underline that extends to the right.

P.S. Remember to always check with your healthcare provider before making any changes to your exercise or diet.

Step 1: Change Your R&R

When pressures build and chaos follows, it's easy to react instead of respond. But this kind of R&R can be draining. Over time, reacting to people, problems, and situations can become a habit that adds to the chaos.

Here's the good news: a simple shift can work wonders. Start easing the pressure with a new kind of R&R: responding instead of reacting. When you feel tension rising, making a conscious choice to respond thoughtfully can create a sense of calm. Choosing to respond—rather than react—can lead to an immediate shift in how you experience stress.

Effortless Practice:

Building the habit of responding instead of reacting may take time, but you can make the process easier by deciding ahead of time that it's simple to begin.

- Visualize your unhurried self: Imagine yourself as strong, capable, and poised. See this version of you clearly in your mind, and embrace those qualities as part of who you are. “Park” this image in your mind as a touchstone for reconnecting with your strengths.
- Pause and recall your responsive self: When chaos mounts, take a moment to pause and call on your calm, capable self. Ask: What would this version of me do right now?
- Act on your chosen response: Follow through with a thoughtful response to the situation.

And remember to include classic R&R—rest and relaxation—as part of your routine. Restorative self-care strengthens your ability to respond with calm, making it easier to maintain your new habit of responding instead of reacting.

Step 2: Anchor With Breath

Feeling tossed around by stress? Do you find yourself feeling impatient or reacting instead of responding? One of the most effective ways to anchor yourself is through your breath. Deep, intentional breathing can center you even in the flurry of a crazy day.

If you're new to using breath to relax, it may feel unfamiliar at first. But even the act of trying can feel calming.

Have you ever noticed professional swimmers taking short, quick breaths to energize themselves before a race? That breathing style fuels adrenaline and prepares them for intense activity. In contrast, slow, diaphragmatic breathing —also known as “belly breathing” — activates the parasympathetic nervous system, helping to create and maintain a state of relaxation.

Effortless Practice:

Here's a simple breath exercise for moments of stress:

1. Get comfortable: Sit in a relaxed position and close your eyes. Breathe normally, focusing your attention on your breath. Notice the sensation of air entering and leaving your body.
2. Deepen your breath: Inhale through your nose, filling your belly first, then your chest. Exhale slowly through your nose.
3. Repeat: Continue this pattern at a comfortable pace. Avoid dizziness by keeping your breaths slow and steady.
4. Call in calm: Take at least five deep breaths, then open your eyes and notice the energy shift in your body.

Practicing this exercise daily helps you train your body to call in calm when reaction-mode sets in.

Step 3: Picture Perfect

Reframing a situation can completely change how you experience it. By choosing to view challenges from a new, positive perspective, you can create instant stress relief.

When tension rises, step back and ask yourself how you might see things differently.

Effortless Practice:

Use these questions to explore new angles:

- “Am I seeing this through a half-empty or half-full glass? What would change if I focused on the half-full approach?”
- Do I have to be doing this or can I delegate it?
- “Instead of focusing on what’s wrong, can I identify what’s working well and build on that?”
- Where can I simplify without compromising the results I want?
- “Am I distracted by a more pressing task? What if I prioritized differently and focused my energy on what truly matters right now?”

Fresh perspectives can cut through stress, inspire new ideas, and realign you with your goals.

Step 4: Add Time

Time management is a constant struggle for many women. “Finding more time” often feel like an elusive goal. Time is just time, right?

While you’re not able to add more hours in a day, you can experiment with how you perceive and use time to create the feeling of having more.

How?

Try these practices to invite a new relationship with time and cultivate a sense of spaciousness in your day:

Effortless Practice:

Take On a Mantra...

What would change if you started each day believing you had enough time for everything? How would it feel? How might you approach your day differently if you carried this belief with you?

Each morning, take a moment to repeat this simple phrase:

“I have enough time for everything I need to get done today.”

Let this mantra sink in, and allow it to shape your mindset throughout the day. It’s a powerful way to shift your perception and invite calm into your schedule.

Live the “Spaces In-Between...”

For many of us, the drive to accomplish more leads to overlooking the spaces between tasks, projects, or even thoughts. These in-between moments often go unnoticed—but they hold powerful opportunities.

By tuning in to the spaces between activities, you can:

Acknowledge your progress and celebrate what you've accomplished before moving on.

Reconnect with yourself: Use these moments in between to pause, breathe, and return to balance.

When you pause between “doings,” you allow yourself more time to simply be. This presence can transform your experience of time, making it feel as though it has expanded.

Make Room...

By creating space — both mentally and physically — you can invite more calm and joy into your life. For many women, decluttering their surroundings enhances their sense of time and order.

Try these simple strategies to simplify your environment and save time:

- Declutter your spaces: Tidy up your desktop, email, and calendar to reduce distractions and eliminate unnecessary searching. A sense of order creates a calmer, more efficient environment.
- Organize for ease: Use “point-of-use” principles by storing frequently used items where they're most needed, both at home and in the office.

These small adjustments can streamline your day, free up mental energy, and make room for what truly matters.

Step 5: Steady With Stillness

For some, the most counterintuitive actions can be the most effective when faced with confusion or overwhelm.

We've all heard stories of people facing threats by standing their ground—like staring down a charging animal. While that might not be a strategy most of us would try, turning to face our inner chaos can sometimes be exactly what's needed to regain balance and clarity.

How does this work?

By aligning with your inner confusion through mindful observation, you can invite a sense of internal order.

A few minutes of neutral, nonjudgmental witnessing can help you shift from chaos to mindfulness. When you're more mindful, clarity emerges, allowing you to make better choices in the moment.

Effortless Practice: Stillness Steady

The next time you feel overwhelmed, try this simple practice to ground yourself:

- Get comfortable: Find a quiet place to sit or lie down.
- Breathe and observe: Close your eyes and take a few slow, deep breaths. Allow yourself to feel your body and mind exactly as they are. Let go of judgment—imagine your inner critic taking a hike—and simply observe the moment without trying to change anything.
- Be the witness: Watch your thoughts as they pass by, like leaves floating on a stream or train cars going by. Allow yourself to notice them without attaching to or resisting them. It's okay if they spin or swirl. Just keep inviting yourself to play witness to them.

After 3–5 minutes of neutral observing, you can stop, or you can step it up by shifting into a deeper state of relaxation:

- Recall calm moments: Picture a time when you felt relaxed and everything was flowing smoothly. Feel it all over again and let that remembered feeling settle into your body.
- Expand the feeling: Imagine having more than enough time for everything you want to do. What does that feel like?
- Release tension: Invite your shoulders to soften, your jaw to relax, and your entire body to let go as you deepen your breath.

Spend a few moments savoring the sensation of ease and flow in your body before returning to your day.

When you experiment with stillness and intentional releasing, even briefly, you create space to feel separate from the chaos of a situation. This practice reminds you that you are not your circumstances, allowing clarity and calm to resurface.

Step 6: Quiet Time Quota

A calmer you means a more creative thinker, a clearer decision-maker, a more effective worker, a more patient mom, a more responsive partner, and a better friend.

So why do so many women feel guilty about taking the quiet time they need?

Adding daily quiet time is one of the simplest ways to increase both inner and outer peace. This includes carving out moments of stillness even in chaotic situations.

It might take time for those around you to adjust to this commitment. You may need to set stronger boundaries or practice diplomacy to protect your quiet time. But stick with it—you're worth it!

Whenever possible, start with a plan. The following ideas can help you incorporate more quiet into your days:

Effortless Practice

- Schedule it like an appointment: Add daily quiet time to your planner, just as you would any other important commitment.
- Step away briefly: When chaos strikes, take a moment to escape. Head to the restroom or step outside for a breath of fresh air and a dose of “nature medicine.”
- Redirect commotion: When group efforts—whether with colleagues, family, or children—aren't productive, pause and redirect. Sometimes, a moment of quiet is all that's needed to reset.
- Postpone difficult discussions: If a conversation is heading nowhere or escalating unnecessarily, excuse yourself and reschedule for a better time.

Give Yourself Space to Reset

You deserve a little room to unruffle. Whenever possible, separate yourself from agitation and allow your mind to quiet. Even if you can only manage to do so for a moment. These small moments of calm can make a big difference in your ability to navigate the day with intention, clarity, and grace.

Step 7: Soften Your Schedule

Where's the fire?

Life is busy — there's no denying that. You might need to finish a project, get your kids to school on time, remember to pay bills by their due dates, or arrive at meetings before they start. But beyond these essentials, how often are you chasing deadlines that are entirely self-imposed?

Recognizing the moments where you're adding unnecessary pressure gives you an opportunity to soften your schedule.

Take a moment to ask yourself:

- How long have I been waiting for things to “slow down”?
- Do I think they'll slow down on their own?

If your schedule could use some lightening up, here's how you can take the reins:

Effortless Practice

1. *Revisit your schedule:* Take a good look at your calendar. Are there commitments that can be postponed, delegated, or removed altogether? Consider making small tweaks — or, if needed, bolder changes — to create more breathing room.
2. *Challenge the impossible:* If the idea of changing your schedule feels overwhelming, pause and reflect: If you don't take steps to balance your responsibilities, what will happen to the people, projects, and plans that rely on you if burnout takes over?
3. *Think long-term:* Remember, slowing down is one of the best ways to speed up and catch up. Prioritizing your well-being ensures that you can show up fully for the things and people that matter most.

By softening your schedule, you're not just giving yourself space, you're preserving your energy, focus, and peace of mind. Burnout doesn't have to be part of your story.

By taking small steps now, you can create more balance and help to prevent burnout.

Step 8: Tame Turmoil With Teatime

Sometimes a little help is just a few sips away.

Whether your days are always crazy-busy, or you just have occasional days when your life feels on the edge of out-of-control, somewhere between lunchtime and 5:00, you probably could use a break from the commotion. To help balance impending overwhelm, treat your self to a tasty, nurturing teatime break.

Traditional afternoon “tea” falls at the time of day when most of us feel a natural dip in energy. Instead of fighting the urge to push on, stop long enough to reboot “Taking tea” can help you to regroup and refuel, allowing you to be even more productive once you’ve had an opportunity for a little renewal.

Whether you prefer to go for it—taking traditional tea— or just keep it simple, include a snack with a bit of protein to help keep blood sugar and energy more level for the remainder of the day.

Effortless Practice:

There is a surplus of delicious, healthy teas in this world to choose from. If you don’t have many choices in your local stores, go online for an abundant selection to explore and enjoy.

I prefer loose leaf green and white teas for their flavor and health benefits. The tea plant, *Camellia sinensis*, even when processed as black tea, tends to have less caffeine than most coffees.

Consider exploring both teas and tisanes. Tisanes are “teas” made from fruits, herbs and other ingredients, but have no actual tea leaves in them.

If you're new to tea drinking don't be afraid to experiment and mix flavors. No two are exactly alike.

* Many teas are high in antioxidants, making them a great addition to a healthy diet.

* Certain varieties, like black teas, are higher in caffeine. These, along with some herbal teas like mint and ginger, tend to be stimulating.

* Late in the day, stick to low caffeine choices like white tea, or drink herbal blends or caffeine-free teas that won't interfere with sleep later in the evening.

* For teas that calm and soothe, look for ingredients like chamomile, lavender, lemon balm, valerian, and evening primrose.

If you're in the habit of grabbing a cup of coffee in the morning, I get it. I love coffee! Still, I invite you to broaden your horizons by exploring the pallet pleasures and health benefits of drinking tea.



Congratulations on completing the eight steps! As you move forward, remember that cultivating calm doesn't require a complete overhaul of your life. Small, intentional steps can create meaningful shifts, helping you navigate life's chaos with greater clarity and ease. By practicing the seven steps, you're not only inviting more tranquility into your days, you're also nurturing the resilience and balance needed to thrive.

About the author



Valerie Mirto is a Transformational Coach, author, and entrepreneur specializing in Success Through Self-care™. She has over 20 years of experience helping women transform themselves personally and professionally to create the lives they imagine living. Her passion remains helping women create healthier, happier, more authentic, successful lives — *without trading what matters most.*

Her experience as a self-employed single-mother enables her to understand the challenges and tradeoffs that come with operating at full speed, while fending off overwhelm. Her programs and services are designed to support women in championing alignment, expanded thinking, and the incalculable value of treating themselves beautifully to counteract stress.

Find more success, mindfulness, and self-care support at **coachvalerie.com** or follow Valerie on Instagram: **@lifecoachvalerie**



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